

# Planning Context and Proposed Ohio River South Shore Trail (ORSST) Alignment

Iroquois and Shawnees. It would later be called “Logstown” by the British, after Logstown Run that ran past the village to the river.

After the French and Indian War (1754-63) and the takeover of the region by the British, the Indian people lost title to the land. Logstown was virtually deserted. This was the first of a series of “ups” and “downs” the town would experience under any name in its 250-year history.

It is popularly believed that Aliquippa was named after Queen Aliquippa, a staunchly pro-British Iroquois leader who ruled over what is now Greater Pittsburgh in the mid 18th Century. But that may not be altogether accurate. In the late 19th Century, Pittsburgh and Lake Erie Railroad developed an amusement park on Crows Island just offshore from Logstown, and droves of Pittsburgh residents would take the train to the park to picnic and enjoy the weekend. In keeping with its policy of naming stops on the line for prominent Indian leaders of the Colonial era, the railroad named it, “Aliquippa Park” and the adjacent railroad terminal, “Aliquippa.” So, by 1892, part of the village of Logstown incorporated itself as the Borough of Aliquippa.

In the late 1800s, when the Pittsburgh region was emerging as a major steel making hub, population upriver in Pittsburgh exploded with new European immigrants to fill steel working jobs.

By 1900, Jones and Laughlin Steel Corp., which had established itself on Pittsburgh’s South Side, sought expansion downriver. The company bought the Ohio River island and by 1909 had demolished the amusement park, filled in the back channel and began erecting what would become the largest, integrated steel mill in the world, stretching seven miles along the river. In the process, J&L expanded Woodlawn, an unincorporated village in neighboring Hopewell Township. It was incorporated as a borough in 1908, and homes and businesses were erected to accommodate a new immigrant influx of steel workers.

The new Woodlawn was in every way a company town. J&L laid out the town in a series of “plans” identified by numbers such as “Plan 6,” “Plan 11,” etc., and settled people from various racial and ethnic sources separately in each plan. That arrangement discouraged people of varied backgrounds and languages to integrate into the American society, but it was an efficient way in the short run for the company to reduce language and social conflict among neighbors. For example, Serbs and Croats were settled in Logstown which by the early 1900s had been absorbed into Woodlawn.

In 1910, Woodlawn was the jewel of Pittsburgh-area communities, according to an article in a Pittsburgh newspaper:

“There is no more active place in the Pittsburgh district today than Woodlawn with its hundreds of pretty homes, its clean paved streets, its dozens of modern stores, its churches, schools, lodges, clubs and ample transportation facilities. Its streets are paved with brick in the business section and macadam in the residence section, concrete sidewalks, shade trees, sewerred and electric lighted,” the article continued. “It has every modern utility such as natural gas, electric light, a pure and potable water supply and ample police and fire protection.”

With a steel workers’ union in place at the mill and with improved wages and working conditions, Woodlawn flourished. Franklin Avenue, the borough’s main street leading down to the mill, bustled with economic activity, and stores bulged with shoppers. The railroad station had been relocated to a spot at the bottom of Franklin Avenue near the plant’s main gate, but its railroad moniker, “Aliquippa,” remained. Aliquippa and Woodlawn consolidated in 1928, and the Woodlawn name was dropped to conform to the name of the railroad depot. Curiously, the former Aliquippa became known as the neighborhood of “West Aliquippa,” although it is located at the northeastern tip of the community.

The company maintained control over the community even during the Great Depression of the 1930s. While millions were displaced by unemployment, the company kept its skilled workforce until better times by reducing work hours rather than wholesale layoffs. To help workers’ families deal with the tough times, the company promoted a system of vegetable gardens on unused company property, farmed by the under employed workers’ families.

Demand for steel to fight World War II dramatically improved the economy of the area as the Aliquippa Works pumped out millions of tons of rolled steel to build ship hulls and tank armor among other weapons needs. Steel workers boasted with justified pride that the Aliquippa Works led the nation in the logistical job of winning the war.

During the middle of World War II when demand for steel was highest to feed the victory effort, as many as 9,000 people were employed at the J&L Works, and Aliquippa had a population of 27,000.

The economy of the town became more broadly based in the mid 1900s as service businesses grew, nourished by increased workers’ wages. New middle-class and upper-middle class housing developed west of the downtown section with second-generation members of steel workers’ families taking on professional and management jobs to support the area’s economy.

The collapse came one day in 1984 when LTV Corp., the corporate successor to J&L, issued a statement that it would close most of the Aliquippa Works, almost immediately laying off about 8,000 workers.

As sudden as it was, the action was not unexpected. J&L was gone, and LTV was already in reorganizational bankruptcy. Big Steel plants all along the Monongahela and upper Ohio River valleys already had fallen like a line of giant dominoes. The Aliquippa Works was the last and greatest one to fall in Pennsylvania.

The impact was almost immediate. With the flow of workers’ daily traffic gone, downtown Aliquippa became a near ghost town. Stores along Franklin Avenue were shuttered in rapid succession as customers disappeared. The effect on the Borough’s tax base soon followed as J&L obtained drastic tax revaluations of its real-estate holdings including much of the vast plant itself. The deterioration of Franklin Avenue did nothing to improve the downward spiral of employment and local tax receipts. Budgetary woes increased to such an extent that, at one point in the mid 1980s, Duquesne

## Section 300 – City of Aliquippa

### Community Character and Demographic Overview

The City of Aliquippa has 3.3 miles of Ohio River frontage within Section 300 of the ORSST study area. The area is entirely industrial with many active industrial businesses and vacant industrial parcels targeted for future industrial development.

The City of Aliquippa consists of approximately 10,956 people and 4,825 households based on 2006 estimated U.S. Census data. The racial makeup of the area is 62 percent White, 36 percent African American, 0.1 percent Hispanic 0.07 percent Native American, and 0.18 percent Asian. The per capital income of the town is \$13,718 and 21.7 percent live below the poverty line, nearly twice Pennsylvania’s rate of 12.1 percent. Also nearly 22.5 percent of the population of the City is 65 years and over, compared to Pennsylvania’s rate of 15.3 percent statewide. Based on 2000 U.S. Census data, there were at the time approximately 719 vacant or abandoned residential units in the City, representing nearly 15 percent of the total housing units and some of the poorest census blocks in all of Beaver County occur in Aliquippa.

### History and Cultural Resources

Aliquippa emerged around 1750 as an Indian village on the back-channel of an Ohio River island. There, French settlers traded with Delawares,



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Light Co. threatened to shut off service to the street lights in the Borough for payment delinquency.

With forced retirement of older steel workers and out-migration of younger families, Aliquippa's population began its drop to 11,734 as recorded in the 2000 Census. The final blow came in 2000 when LTV Corp., the corporate successor of Jones & Laughlin, sold the tin mill, the only remaining section of the plant that still operated, to U. S. Steel Corp. That Pittsburgh-based steel maker announced it would close the tin mill, resulting in the layoff of 400 steel workers.

One day in the late 1980s -- in one of the most poignant moments of the city's history -- veteran steel workers who had lost their jobs and then their retirement benefits gathered at the railroad tunnel at the entrance of the old plant to demonstrate their frustrations. Dubbed the "Tunnel Rats," the group of steel workers were arrested by local police for disorderly conduct. There were tears in the eyes of some of the arresting officers as they were forced to handcuff their own family members who were among the Tunnel Rats.

At about the same time, Aliquippa Borough Council in 1987 re-chartered the Borough as a city, giving the community broader tax powers under Pennsylvania municipal law.

For the portions of the City of Aliquippa that are located within or near Section 300 there are two sites listed on the National Register of Historic Places. Most of the ORSST Study Area consists of land formally part of the Jones & Laughlin Steel Mill. A few of the administrative buildings from the complex remain in the vicinity, but none appear to pre-date the late 1940s. The City's 2009 Revitalization Plan does suggest the J&L head quarters building could be restored and reused. Identified historic resources within the study area include:

- *Pittsburgh & Lake Erie Aliquippa Railroad Station (Listed on the National Register of Historic Places);*
- *Jones B. F. Memorial Library (Listed on the National Registered of Historic Places); and*
- *Pennsylvania Historical Museum Commission Marker for the National Labor Relations Board vs. the J&L Steel Corp. U.S. Supreme Court Ruling in 1937 for Labor Rights (marker is located on the south side of the Franklin Avenue underpass).*

### Environmental

**River's Edge and Habitat:** The river's edge in this area is highly disturbed, both from the legacy of the former steel making operation as well from current industrial activities. There are areas where bulkheading exists as well as moorings and other structures focused on marine navigation and bulk material transfer. The river edge topography changes fairly significantly in elevation within close proximity of the river. Despite the industrial activities and legacy, significant areas of vegetation cover still exist.

Based on field observations, there are areas of erosion disturbance along the river's edge as well as significant areas of invasive exotic vegetation with poor soil stabilization characteristics.



*The Ohio River's Edge in Aliquippa near the Confluence of Logstown Run*

### Streams and Stormwater:

Logstown Run historically ran as a stream in the location of where Franklin Avenue exists today. The stream runs underground, via an underground sewer line. It runs underneath the Franklin Avenue underpass and Woodlawn Road, where an outfall exists. The City's Revitalization Plan mentioned the fact that the underpass area is a "bottle neck" for stormwater conveyance. At this point the stream is day-lighted until it reaches the Ohio River. The stream corridor portion of Logstown Run is eroded and has significant sediment loading from the sewer outfall.

As with many older urban communities, much of the City's sewage system consist of combined sewer outfalls (CSOs), so opportunities to reduce stormwater flowing directly into the sewer system through improved site-specific infiltration projects that help to alleviate CSO impacts on the environment should be integrated into trail design projects wherever possible. The City's Revitalization Plan specifically emphasizes the importance of such projects in addressing the reduction of CSO issues and water quality.

### Transportation/Traffic

PA Route 51 is the main east/west roadway that parallels the Ohio River from the City of Pittsburgh through Monaca, across the Monaca Rochester Bridge and to the west. PA Route 51 is designated by PennDOT as the Pennsylvania Bicycle Route A through the entire ORSST Study Area, including through Section 300. PA Route 51 in Section 300 has an average daily traffic volume of approximately 9,300.

Franklin Avenue Underpass is the one point of vehicular access connecting PA Route 51 under the CSX Railroad and it serves more than 2.5 miles of industrial land. Once the BCED portion of Woodlawn Road that will extend from Section 200 to Section 300 is completed, vehicular traffic will have two potential routes to access PA Route 51. Currently the Franklin Avenue underpass is the only viable option and is heavily utilized by industrial truck traffic and can only handle one-lane of trucks down the centerline of the underpass due to height restrictions created by its curved ceiling. Due to the cross section of the underpass, the sidewalk widths on each side are only 5'-6" wide and have safety barriers constructed out of guiderails which creates a prison-like effect for pedestrians. Bicyclists are required to travel with vehicular traffic in the roadway which is especially harrowing since the underpass is dark and nearly 70' long.

Woodlawn Road in Section 300 varies in condition. The segment from the USG entrance roadway, past Franklin Avenue to the eastern intersection with Steel Street has been improved. The stretch of roadway west of the USG entrance roadway is proposed for reconstruction and the portion along the former Tin Mill site is also targeted for reconstruction long term. As sections of Woodlawn Road are reconstructed the ownership of the roadway has typically been conveyed to the City of Aliquippa. The portion of Woodlawn Road east of the BCED/BET-TECH Tin Mill Property to Section 400 Section Line is privately owned and currently the responsibility of the adjacent private landowners. This segment of roadway is currently in very poor condition.



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## Economic Development

The City of Aliquippa has recently adopted a Revitalization Plan (December 2009) for a blighted area of its downtown which includes an area that extends down Franklin Avenue, underneath the CSX Railroad to the Ohio River. This plan indentifies a comprehensive series of improvement recommendations including several focused on multi-modal transportation improvements as well as increased public park access along the Ohio River. The following is a summary of the recommendations that have relevance to the ORSST Feasibility Study:

- *Employ a “complete streets” approach for upgrading all roadways in the area including the entire Franklin Avenue corridor. The plan specifically outlines the importance of creating a balanced transportation and land use environment where pedestrians, bicycle and vehicular needs are all met in a fundamental way and to create a pedestrian and trail network that connects the downtown and the proposed ORSST and the Ohio River;*
- *Create a public park and Ohio River overlook with a boat launch and other public amenities to create new public access to the river’s edge;*
- *Improve the gateway appearance to the industrial park area;*
- *Implement “green” improvements including reducing the amount of impervious areas through the transformation of such areas with porous paving, new plantings and innovative stormwater infiltration areas to provide pretreatment of stormwater flows prior to direct infiltration and discharge into the Ohio River; and*
- *Renovate the historic train station building as a workforce development incubator, possibly tied to other building reuse plans in the area as well as with regional educational institutions.*

## Proposed ORSST Route and Alternatives

There is one main route through Section 300 and one alternative route for a short segment of the overall section.

### Proposed ORSST Route Description through Section 300

The proposed ORSST trail route through Section 300 would parallel existing or future Woodlawn Road from the BCED property at the eastern portion of West Aliquippa to the Hopewell Township Municipal Line with South Heights Borough, near the Ambridge Aliquippa Bridge. The trail will consist of a continuous 10’ wide side path with a 3’-5’ wide planted buffer along the railroad side of Woodlawn Road.

### Route Characteristics and Issues

Franklin Avenue Underpass Area: The truck traffic volumes and turning movements around the Franklin Avenue underpass could create conflicts between the potential high volumes of truck traffic and bicyclists. In addition, the grade of Woodlawn Road as it approaches the underpass area, from both directions, would require any dedicated trail facilities be paved with asphalt to protect against potential wash outs from stormwater

runoff. The underpass itself is very narrow and has limited pedestrian and bicycle accommodations. This underpass serves as the only access point to the ORSST from the majority of Aliquippa’s residents and is identified in the City’s Revitalization Plan as an important pedestrian and bicycle linkage between the downtown, the proposed trail and the riverfront park. Functional and aesthetic improvements will greatly enhance the real and perceived safety of the underpass. These improvements include replacing the make-shift pedestrian barriers constructed from old guiderail with a more visually open material, such as vinyl coated chain link fencing, painting the interior of the underpass, and providing ample lighting.



Franklin Avenue Underpass Sidewalk

BCED Future Woodlawn Road from the Section 200 Section Line through the BCED Property to the USG Entrance Roadway: As a continuation of the same segment located in Section 200, this segment is targeted for a 10’ wide gravel side path to be located on the side of the roadway closest to the railroad. BCED is actively pursuing funding to construct a new roadway in this location and if additional engineering and construction funding can be secured, the trail and roadway could potentially be constructed concurrently.

Unimproved Woodlawn Road from Steel Street to the Eastern Property Line of the BCED/BET-TECH Tin Mill Property. This segment is part of the Woodlawn Road that has not been improved and is targeted for a 10’ wide gravel side path on the railroad side of the roadway. Funding to include the engineering of the trail in the final roadway engineering drawings and specifications should be pursued to ensure that the trail and the roadway can be constructed concurrently. The location of the trail on the railroad side of Woodlawn Road is important since it would allow the trail to be nearly continuous and not be broken by driveway curb cuts.

Woodlawn Road from BCED/BET-TECH Tin Mill Property to Section 400 Section Line: The ability to create a public trail along the portions of existing Woodlawn Road from the eastern end of the BCED-BET-TECH Tin

Mill Property will need to be determined due to current ownership issues. Currently, this segment of roadway privately owned and the maintenance responsibilities for this stretch of roadway is the burden of the property owners. The roadway is currently in very poor condition and would require reconstruction and the conveyance of ownership to the municipality if a public trail was located in this area.

### Proposed Route Lengths:

Total Length of Route through the City of Aliquippa (Section 300) 10’ Wide Multi Use Path = 3.3 miles

### Identified ORSST Routing Alternatives in Section 300

#### Alternative 300A

Description: This alternative creates a bypass route around the Franklin Avenue underpass area. The route for this alternative would direct the trail over Franklin Avenue via the unused portions of the span that once served the railroad.

Issues and Opportunities: At one time the span over Franklin Avenue accommodated at least five mainline railroad tracks in this location, plus an existing siding that crosses Woodlawn Road, at-grade, west of Franklin Avenue. A trail could be built on the Woodlawn Road side of the siding, across the span and then turned to meet Woodlawn Road on the east side of Franklin Avenue near the west Steel Street intersection. The trail could possibly align with the proposed connector trail that would extend along the west side of Steel Street to the proposed riverfront park and boat launch.



Franklin Avenue Underpass Area Showing Potential Alternative 300A Route Above

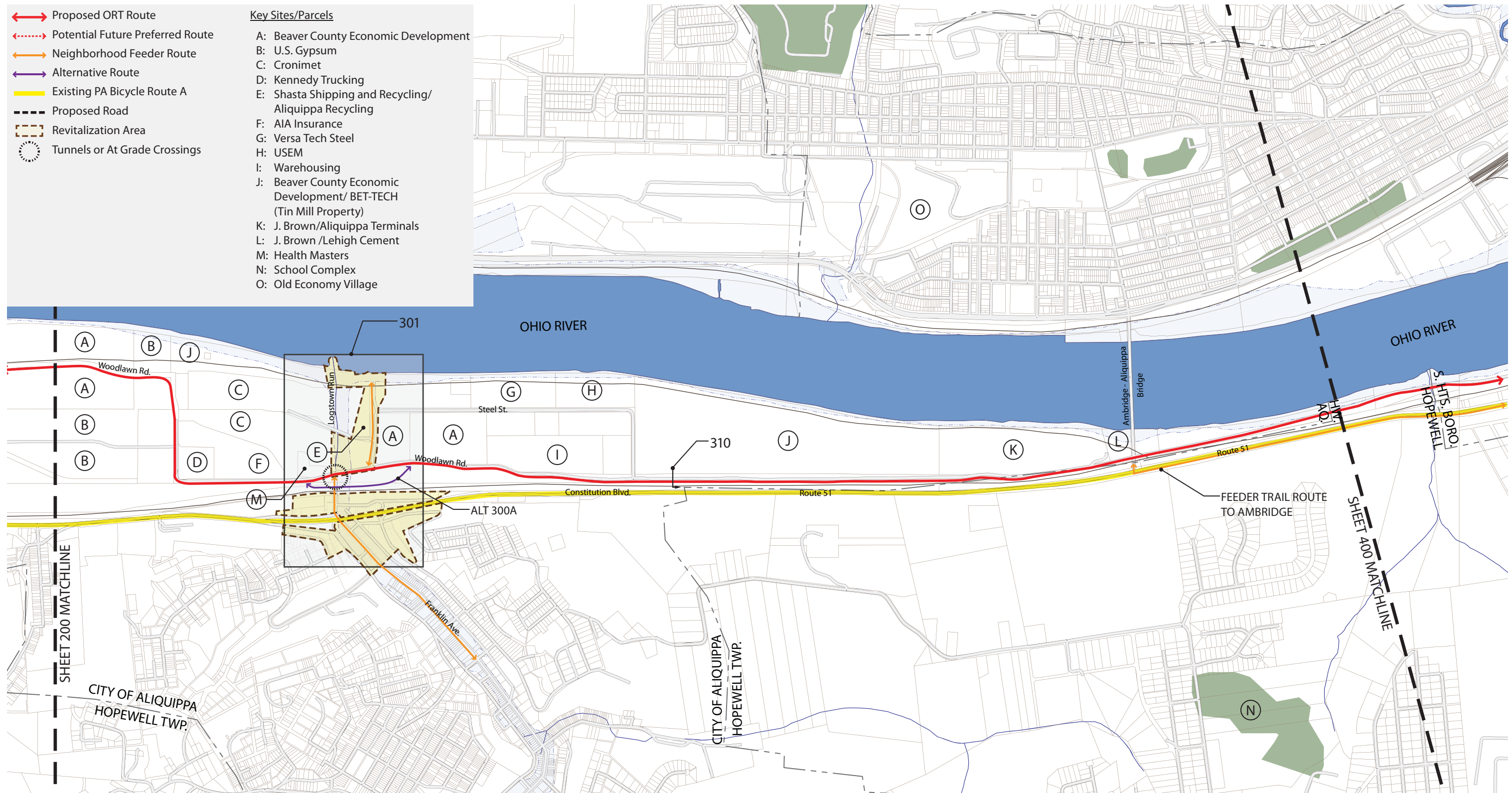


LEGEND

- ←→ Proposed ORT Route
- ⋯ Potential Future Preferred Route
- ↔ Neighborhood Feeder Route
- ↔ Alternative Route
- Existing PA Bicycle Route A
- - - Proposed Road
- ⬡ Revitalization Area
- ⊙ Tunnels or At Grade Crossings

Key Sites/Parcels

- A: Beaver County Economic Development
- B: U.S. Gypsum
- C: Cronimet
- D: Kennedy Trucking
- E: Shasta Shipping and Recycling/ Aliquippa Recycling
- F: AIA Insurance
- G: Versa Tech Steel
- H: USEM
- I: Warehousing
- J: Beaver County Economic Development/ BET-TECH (Tin Mill Property)
- K: J. Brown/Aliquippa Terminals
- L: J. Brown /Lehigh Cement
- M: Health Masters
- N: School Complex
- O: Old Economy Village

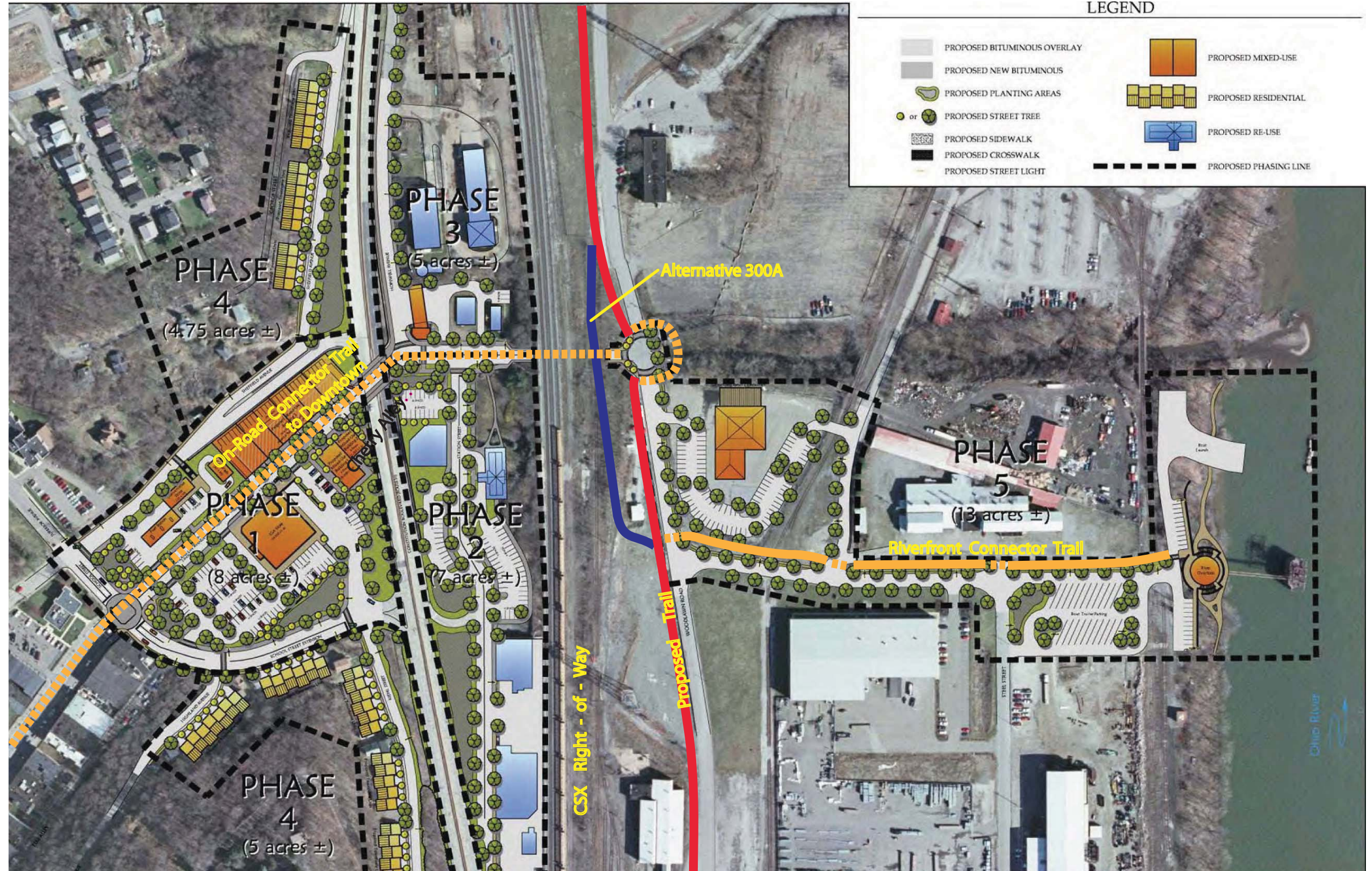


SCALE: Not to Scale NORTH



LEGEND

- Proposed 10' Wide Side Path Trail Route
- Alternative Side Path Trail Route
- Neighborhood Feeder 10' Wide Side Path Trail Route
- - - Neighborhood Feeder On-Road Signed Trail Route



LEGEND

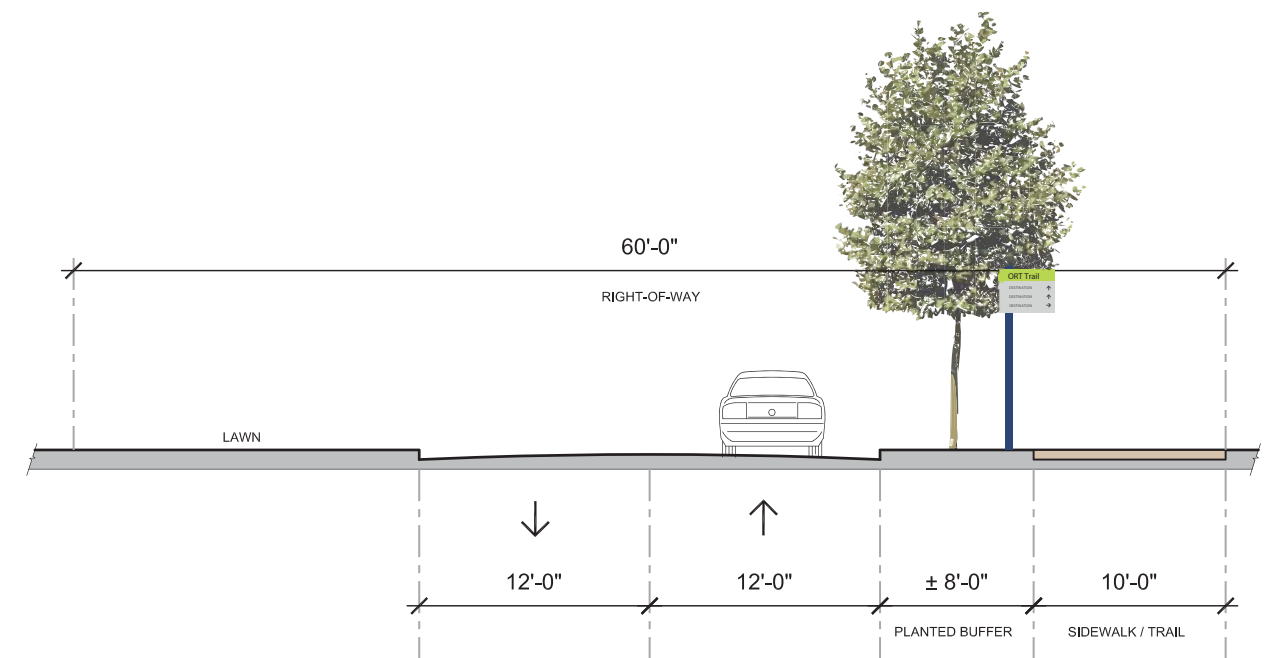
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| <span style="background-color: lightgray; border: 1px solid gray; display: inline-block; width: 20px; height: 10px;"></span> PROPOSED BITUMINOUS OVERLAY | <span style="background-color: orange; border: 1px solid black; display: inline-block; width: 20px; height: 10px;"></span> PROPOSED MIXED-USE   |
| <span style="background-color: gray; border: 1px solid gray; display: inline-block; width: 20px; height: 10px;"></span> PROPOSED NEW BITUMINOUS          | <span style="background-color: yellow; border: 1px solid black; display: inline-block; width: 20px; height: 10px;"></span> PROPOSED RESIDENTIAL |
| <span style="border-bottom: 2px solid green; width: 20px; display: inline-block;"></span> PROPOSED PLANTING AREAS                                        | <span style="background-color: blue; border: 1px solid black; display: inline-block; width: 20px; height: 10px;"></span> PROPOSED RE-USE        |
| <span style="color: green;">●</span> or <span style="color: green;">●</span> PROPOSED STREET TREE                                                        | <span style="border-bottom: 2px dashed black; width: 20px; display: inline-block;"></span> PROPOSED PHASING LINE                                |
| <span style="border: 1px solid gray; display: inline-block; width: 20px; height: 10px;"></span> PROPOSED SIDEWALK                                        |                                                                                                                                                 |
| <span style="background-color: black; border: 1px solid black; display: inline-block; width: 20px; height: 10px;"></span> PROPOSED CROSSWALK             |                                                                                                                                                 |
| <span style="color: yellow;">—</span> PROPOSED STREET LIGHT                                                                                              |                                                                                                                                                 |

301

SCALE: Not to Scale

Base Plan: Revitalization Plan for the City of Aliquippa, December 2009





310 BCED - AND OTHER WOODLAWN RD. AREAS WITH 60' RIGHT-OF-WAY OR GREATER (PROPOSED)  
SCALE: 1"=10'